

THE UNIVERSAL HOUSE OF JUSTICE

1998-12-14

1 This message is to bring you up to date on the situation of the bahá'ís in
2 iran. All those known to have been arrested in connection with the bahá'í
3 institute of higher education (bihe) have been released, with the excep-
4 tion of the following friends in isfahan, who were arrested in early october
5 and are understood to be still detained:

mr. z iaullah m irzapanah mr. f arzad khajeh

dr. Sina h akiman mr. h abibullah f erdosian

6 The authorities called upon many of those arrested in relation to the bihe
7 to sign a statement committing themselves to cease serving in this institution
8 and not to associate with it in the future. All refused to sign, since the opera-
9 tion of the institute contravenes no law of the country. one of the effects of
10 these widespread raids and arrests in iran was to bring about a rededication
11 among many of the friends there to their commitment to provide educational
12 opportunities for the young bahá'ís who have been so callously denied access
13 to the higher education facilities in the country of their birth.

14 The bihe has resumed its activities for the new academic year, although
15 its functioning is still hampered by the loss of equipment, especially com-puters,
which it suffered in the raids, equipment that has not been returned.

16 The announcement by the friends in iran inviting the bahá'í students to
17 resume their studies was made throughout the country at a recent Nineteen
18 day feast. There has been no reaction from the government as yet.289.1

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290 m e S a g e S f r o m T h e u n i v e r S a l h o u S e o f j u S T i c e

291 65in September 1996 we were informed that the final year of high school

292 had been designated a pre-university year, and that bahá'í students had

293 been barred from attending it. This restriction brought with it a number of
294 disadvantages to those affected, such as limiting their access to many employment
opportunities and making it difficult for them to obtain a driving license. we are pleased to
be able to report that this discrimination against
295 bahá'í youth appears to have come to an end very recently, and they are now
296 able to register for the pre-university year in the high schools. it remains to
297 be seen whether they will be awarded the certificate for successful completion of the
year. The friends in iran feel that international pressure on the
298 government of iran is likely to have been instrumental in bringing this
299 about. . . .

At the same time . . . the harassment and intimidation of the bahá'ís

300 in that country has in no way abated, and flurries of arrests continue to occur. often
those arrested are released after a short time. Typical are the

cases of three friends—mr. derakhshan fanaiyan, mrs. minu zamani

(fanaiyan) and mr. hossain mazlumi-Nosratabad—who were arrested

in the town of damavand on 17 october; information has just been

301 received that they have been released. . . . they are very much part of
302 the pattern of harassment. for example, five friends engaged in teaching
303 bahá'í children's classes were recently arrested in the tribal area of boyer
304 Ahmadi-ye in western central iran; further arrests are reported to have
305 taken place during the last two weeks of November in Tankabon and Sari, in the
region north of Tehran, and four friends are believed to have
306 been detained . . .

307 you will have received our email of 1 december enclosing the statement
308 of the lawyer who appealed on behalf of the convicted friends in mash-

had, mr. Sirus zabihi-m oghaddam, mr. h edayat kashefi-Najafabadi and

309 mr. Ataollah hamid-Nasirizadeh. Nothing further is known of their situ-
310 ation as yet. it should also be remembered that four other bahá'ís remain

condemned to death in iran, two—mr. musa Talebi and mr. zabihullah

mahrami—for apostasy, and two—mr. kayvan khalajabadi and mr. beh-

311 nam mithaqi—for bahá'í activities. They were condemned some years ago,
312 and their ultimate fate is still uncertain. . . .

313 forts on behalf of these and all the bahá'ís in iran who steadfastly bear
314 sufferings out of loyalty to the b lessed b eauty.

Department of tHe secretariat289.4

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Resignation from the Continental Board of Counselors

[signed: The Universal House of Justice]